

Session 11: Retaliation and Nonviolence

Key Takeaways

- Jesus commands his followers to “not resist in the same manner” as one who does evil against us. He calls us instead to a form of active response that overcomes dehumanization by reasserting our humanity, though at great cost.
- In Matthew 5:39, the Greek word *antistēnai*, often translated as “resist,” is a compound of *anti*+*stēnai*. It echoes the use of *anti* (“in place of”) from the previous verse, giving the sense of “resist-in-kind.”
- In Jesus’ context, a backhanded slap on the right cheek was a degrading insult, whereas an openhanded slap on the left cheek was less dishonoring. Turning the left cheek would confront the one slapping by rejecting the dishonor and challenging them to face the humanity of the one they sought to demean.
- The case studies about the coat and the mile refer directly to laws in Jewish and Roman societies, respectively.

Case Study 5: Retaliation & NonViolence

- a 38 **You have heard that it was said** ,
b “An eye **in recompense for (ἀντί)** an eye,
b and a tooth **in recompense for (ἀντί)** a tooth.”

- a' 39 **And I say to you** ,
b' do not resist **-in-kind (ἀντί)** an evil person.

- a But **whoever** slaps you on your right cheek,
b turn the other **to him** also.

- a' 40 and **to the one who** wants to sue you and take your shirt,
b' release **to him** also your coat,

- a" 41 and **whoever** forces you to go one mile,
b" go **with him** two.

- a 42 **To the one who asks of you** ,
b **give** ,

- a' **And to the one who wants to borrow from you,**
b' **don't turn away .**

Matthew 5:38-42. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: The Messianic Torah (2024).

Jesus quotes from a law governing the bounds of retaliation that appears three times in the Torah. It comes the closest to Jesus offering a “counter” teaching to the Torah, a true “antithesis.”

Exodus 21:22–25 NIV

If people are fighting and hit a pregnant woman and she gives birth prematurely but there is no serious injury, the offender must be fined whatever the woman’s husband demands and the court allows.

But if there is serious injury, you are to take **life for life, eye for eye, tooth for tooth, hand for hand, foot for foot, burn for burn, wound for wound, bruise for bruise.**

Leviticus 24:18–20 ESV

Whoever takes an animal’s life shall make it good, life for life. If anyone injures his neighbor, as he has done it shall be done to him, **fracture for fracture, eye for eye, tooth for tooth; whatever injury he has given a person shall be given to him.**

Also see [Deuteronomy 19:20-21](#)

This is referred to in Latin as *lex talionis*, “law of retaliation,” by which the guilty party suffers the same damage that the injured party experienced.

Jesus actually quotes a version of this idea later in the Sermon ([Matt. 7:2](#)), and it was widespread in the ancient Near East, as well as in Judaism.

Matthew 7:2 NIV

For in the same way you judge others, you will be judged,
and with the measure you use, it will be measured to you.

This principle was already ancient by the time of Jesus, and even of ancient Israel. We find it in the earliest law codes of the oldest human civilizations, including those of Sumer (the laws of Ur-Nammu and Eshnunna) and Hammurabi.

There is an ancient debate about whether the penalty was literal or financial, and examples of both can be found in the Bible and in the ancient Near East.

“These verses formulate the law of talion, or exact equivalence for injury, usually understood to mean identical physical injury inflicted in retaliation for physical injury suffered. This legal principle was first introduced by Hammurabi and finds expression in such laws as these:

If a lord has destroyed the eye of a member of the ruling class, they shall destroy his eye.

If he has broken a lord’s bone, they shall break his bone.

If a lord has knocked out a tooth of a lord of his own rank, they shall knock out his tooth.

Prior to Hammurabi, monetary compensation, not physical retaliation, was the rule for inflicting bodily injury. This principle is operative in the laws of Ur-nammu, Eshnunna, and the Hittites, as well as in the Middle Assyrian laws.

With the growth of urbanization and centralized government as well as the increased importance of maintaining domestic tranquility, the state more and more tended to encroach upon the private domain. Physical violence became an issue of public welfare, and the state began to regulate the payments for various types of injuries. In a revolutionary development, Hammurabi categorized assault and battery as criminal conduct to be prosecuted by the state. The central government took on the responsibility of protecting the public and preserving the security of its citizens. The *lex talionis* strove to achieve exact justice: only one life for one life, only one eye for one eye, and so forth. In pursuit of this goal, however, the laws allowed physical retaliation and vicarious punishment and did not accept the principle of equal justice for all but, rather, adjusted penalties according to social class.”

Sarna, Nahum M. (2003). [*The JPS Torah Commentary: Exodus*](#). Jewish Publication Society. 125-126.

Although this legal principle may sound negative to us, people of the time viewed it as a positive and useful ideal.

“The rule of *lex talionis* ... was designed to prevent two wrongs—(1) severe retribution that did not fit the crime and also (2) self-appointed vigilante action and blood-feuds. It is all too easy for revenge to get out of hand ... and for well-intentioned actions to become violent and do more damage than the original crime, spiraling into more violence and instability. This is why the *lex talionis* exists and why it continues to be a part of our own justice system in the West.”

Pennington, Jonathan (2017). [*The Sermon on the Mount and Human Flourishing*](#). Baker Academic. 195-196.

We will only imagine Jesus as rejecting or countering this law if we view it as negative or as a command that one must exact retribution on enemies. However, the law was designed to prevent violence from escalating. It was not a command that one had to demand recompense for any and every wrong suffered.

Jesus’ recommended response to wrongdoing functions similarly to the first two case studies, which isolate a deep heart value, a character disposition that manifests itself in public behavior.

- Contempt > Murder
- Lust > Adultery
- Desire for justice > Self-defined violent retribution

The idea of letting God avenge on your behalf instead of taking vengeance into your own hands is a consistent theme in the Old Testament.

Deuteronomy 32:35 Instructor's Translation

It is **mine to avenge; I will repay.**

Psalms 94:1 Instructor's Translation

Yahweh is **the elohim who avenges.**

1 Samuel 24:12 Instructor's Translation

May the Lord judge between you and me. And may **Yahweh avenge** the wrongs you have done to me, but my hand will not touch you.

Romans 12:19 NIV

Do not take revenge, my dear friends, but **leave room for God's wrath**, for it is written: "It is mine to avenge; I will repay," says the Lord.

"What Jesus is rejecting here is vengeance executed on a personal level ... The law of reciprocity is not utterly repudiated, but taken out of human hands to be placed in divine hands."

Davies, W. D. & Allison Jr., Dale C. (2004). [Matthew 1-7 \(International Critical Commentary\)](#). T&T Clark International. 540.

Retaliation vs. Nonviolent Response

Jesus' response to this teaching is to expand upon it, revealing the deeper character issues at work beneath this law. Jesus' choice of words is determined by the word of the *lex talionis* law.

Matthew 5:38-39 Instructor's Translation

You have heard that it was said,

"An eye in place of/in recompense for (ἀντί) eye,

and a tooth in place of/in recompense for (ἀντί) tooth."

And I say to you, do not resist-in-kind (ἀντι στῆναι) an evil person;

antistemi = anti- "against", -stemi "stand" or "resist-in-kind"

Jesus (and Matthew as translator into Greek) chose an interesting verb to describe "opposition," *antistemi*.

The verb can be generally used for "oppose/stand against" (as in [Acts 6:10, 13:18](#)). But also "to set up in opposition" or "to match with, compare" (See [Liddell-Scott](#) on *anthistemi*).

In this context, the verb seems chosen because of the retaliatory nuance of the word *anti*, meaning "in exchange for." In other words, Jesus is addressing forms of retaliation where you do back ("resist in kind") to your offender what they did to you.

"The first syllable in the Greek verb *anti-stenai* translated as 'resist' corresponds to the preposition in the phrase 'an eye for (anti) an eye,' so that there is a direct connection ... to be recognized. Verse 39b then states that one should not resist the evildoer ... by repaying in the same coin. [It is a] rejection of the principle repaying evil with evil (see Proverbs 20:22; 24:29)."

Konradt, Matthias (2020). [The Gospel according to Matthew: A Commentary](#). Baylor University Press. 93.

He is not describing confronting injustice through legal means, nor is he advocating for civil disobedience or protest. He addresses situations where an injury damages my honor, and in my quest for restored honor, I seek revenge and retaliation.

This is how the apostles understood Jesus' teaching.

1 Thessalonians 5:15 NASB

See that no one **repays** (ἀποδίδωμι) another with (ἀντί) evil for evil, but always seek after that which is good for one another and for all people.

Romans 12:14–21 NASB

¹⁴ Bless those who persecute you; bless and do not curse ...

¹⁷ Never **pay back** (ἀποδίδωμι) evil for (ἀντί) evil to anyone. Respect what is right in the sight of all men.

¹⁸ If possible, so far as it depends on you, be at peace with all men.

¹⁹ Never take your own revenge, beloved, but leave room for the anger of God, for it is written, "Vengeance is mine, I will repay," says the Lord.

²⁰ "But if your enemy is hungry, feed him, and if he is thirsty, give him a drink; for in so doing you will heap burning coals on his head."

²¹ Do not be overcome by evil, but overcome evil with good.

Jesus is expressing an ideal ethic that requires us to look deep inside and then look out at those with whom we have conflicts. Jesus wants his followers to be people who break the spiral of violence, who resist the urge for payback, and come up with new, creative responses that force the matter toward resolution.

Our translations, "do not resist," unfortunately, do not capture this nuance of meaning in the Greek. As a result, it sounds like Jesus is saying, "Do nothing in response." However, after examining his four examples, it is clear he does not mean "do nothing."

Slap / Turn the Cheek

"Slap on the right cheek, offer the left." The slap (Greek: *hrapidzein*) is not about significant physical injury, but a public insult. To slap someone was not to physically harm them, but to damage their honor and public reputation.

2 Corinthians 11:20 NIV

In fact, you even put up with anyone who enslaves you or **exploits** you or **takes advantage** of you or exalts themselves or **slaps you in the face**.

Job 16:10 NIV

People open their mouths to jeer at me; they **strike my cheek in scorn** and unite together against me.

Lamentations 3:30 NIV

Let him **offer his cheek** to one who would **strike** him, and let him be filled with **disgrace**.

The mention of the "right hand" and "left cheek" is specific and intentional. A slap to the right cheek required the slapper to use the back of the right hand, doubly dishonoring and a worse insult. Jewish tradition viewed

the backhand slap as more dishonorable than the forehand slap.

“Mishnah Bava Qamma 8:6

A He who boxes the ear of his fellow pays him a sela.

B R. Judah says in the name of R. Yose the Galilean, “A maneh.

C [If] he smacked him, he pays him two hundred zuz.

D [If] it is with the back of his hand, he pays him four hundred zuz.

E [If] he (1) tore at his ear, (2) pulled his hair, (3) spit, and the spit hit him, (4) pulled off his cloak, (5) pulled apart the hairdo of a woman in the marketplace,

F he pays four hundred zuz.

G This is the governing principle: Everything is in accord with one’s station.”

Neusner, Jacob (1991). [*The Mishnah: A New Translation*](#). Yale University Press. 521.

“Matthew evidently mentions the right cheek in order to make plain that the reference is to the backhanded insult (cf. Mishnah Bava Qamma 8:6; to strike the right cheek with the right hand, one must hit backhandedly).”

Davies, W. D. & Allison Jr., Dale C. (2004). [*Matthew, vol. 1 \(International Critical Commentary\)*](#). T&T Clark International. 543.

“A backhanded blow to the right cheek did not imply shattered teeth (‘tooth for tooth’ was a separate statement); it was an insult, the severest public affront to a person’s dignity (see [Job 16:10](#); [Lam. 3:30](#); Mishnah Baba Qamma 8:6; Plut. Platonic Questions 9.4, Mor. 1010F). God’s prophets had sometimes suffered such ill-treatment ([1 Kgs 22:24](#); [2 Chron. 18:23](#); [Isa. 50:6](#); Jeremiah 1963: 29), as Jesus would himself ([26:67](#); cf. [Mic. 5:1](#)). Yet though this was more an affront to honor, a challenge, than a physical injury, ancient Near Eastern societies typically provided legal recourse for this offense within the lex talionis regulations (e.g., Hammurabi 202–6; cf. Gaius Inst. 3.220).”

Keener, Craig S. (2009). [*The Gospel of Matthew: A Socio-Rhetorical Commentary*](#). Eerdmans. 197-198.

“By freely offering one’s other cheek, one demonstrates that one does not value human honor. In a sense, this could constitute a form of resistance by showing contempt for the value of the insulter’s (and perhaps the onlookers’) opinions (Sall. Invective against Marcus Tullius 1; Diog. Laert. 6.2.58; Diogenes Ep. 20). ... Even in a society obsessed with honor and shame (e.g., Sir 1:30), a disciple must be so secure in his or her status before God that he or she can dispense with human honor. Such a person need not avenge lost honor because this person seeks God’s honor rather than his or her own (5:16; 6:1–18).”

Keener, Craig S. (2009). [*The Gospel of Matthew: A Socio-Rhetorical Commentary*](#). Eerdmans. 198.

Jesus says to forgo the insult, but he doesn’t say, “Do nothing!”

“Turning the other cheek” is a bold response that challenges the entire honor-shame system. In that act, you declare their insult to be meaningless. It’s a demonstration that your true honor is rooted in something deeper than your slapper’s evaluation of you.

This is the Selma, Alabama, civil rights march in March 1965. When John Lewis led 600 marchers across the Edmund Pettus Bridge, they were sprayed with fire hoses and attacked by police dogs. They didn’t fight back

to gain revenge, but neither did they run away. It was a refusal to recognize the legitimacy of violent white supremacy. They stood tall and sang hymns about God's love and justice in the face of their oppressor.

Sued for Shirt / Give Your Cloak

The saying takes for granted the fact that the standard form of dress in Jesus' time and place consists of two garments:

- An inner garment/shirt or tunic of linen or wool worn next to the skin, called a *khiton* / χιτών in Greek and *ketonet* / כתנת in Hebrew.
- An outer garment, robe, or cloak made of heavier wool called a *himation* / ἱμάτιον in Greek and *beged* / בגד or *simlah* / שמלה in Hebrew.

Jesus' saying assumes this is a legal case, a lawsuit. Someone is suing you and trying to take your one main piece of clothing. (It was valuable; most people only had one.)

In Jewish legal tradition in the Torah, it was wrong to sue someone and take their outer cloak (think "jacket") because it doubled as a sleeping blanket and was part of survival (Exod. 22:25-27; Deut. 24:12-13).

Exodus 22:25–27 NASB

If you lend money to my people, to the poor among you, you are not to act as a creditor to him; you shall not charge him interest.

If you ever take your neighbor's cloak as a pledge, you are to return it to him before the sun sets, for that is his only covering; it is his cloak for his body. What else shall he sleep in? And it shall come about that when he cries out to me, I will hear him, for I am gracious.

Deuteronomy 24:10–15 NASB

¹⁰ When you make your neighbor a loan of any sort, you shall not enter his house to take his pledge.

¹¹ You shall remain outside, and the man to whom you make the loan shall bring the pledge out to you.

¹² **If he is a poor man, you shall not sleep with his pledge.**

¹³ **When the sun goes down you shall surely return the pledge to him, that he may sleep in his cloak and bless you;** and it will be righteousness for you before the LORD your God.

¹⁴ You shall not oppress a hired servant who is poor and needy, whether he is one of your countrymen or one of your aliens who is in your land in your towns.

¹⁵ You shall give him his wages on his day before the sun sets, for he is poor and sets his heart on it; so that he will not cry against you to the LORD and it become sin in you.

Jesus assumes this is a wrongful suit: It was common for poor people to put up their only belongings, like their clothes, as collateral on a loan. However, Jesus is painting the scene of an unjust lawsuit, brought by someone who is so greedy and selfish that they would take even your shirt.

It's important to see the shock value in Jesus' words, "give him your coat also." If one's tunic has been taken in a wrongful lawsuit, and if you then give them your outer robe, you end up naked, by your own actions!

In other words, Jesus says, don't dig in and try to beat him at his own game by suing him back, which you probably don't have money for anyway. Rather, use radical and shocking generosity to subvert the system of

legal exchange.

But that scandalous generosity will also have a clear interpersonal effect as well, as it will draw public attention (public nakedness usually does!) to your legal opponent's selfish behavior: "What!? He sued that man and left him naked?!"

Jesus is advocating a method of shocking your oppressor's conscience into awareness of their oppressive actions.

"[Jesus' recommended] practice would lead to nudity, an intolerable dishonor in Palestinian Jewish society. Many peasants had only one outer cloak and pursued whatever legal recourse necessary to get it back if it were seized; without the cloak a person would be naked and cold. Because the outer cloak doubled as a poor man's bedding, biblical law permitted no one to take it even as a pledge overnight (Ex. 22:26-27; Deut. 24:12-13); Jesus demands that one surrender the one possession the law explicitly protects from legal seizure. Jesus provides a shockingly graphic, almost humorous, illustration of what he means by nonresistance to force his hearers to consider their values. They value honor and things more than they value the kingdom."

Keener, Craig S. (2009). [*The Gospel of Matthew: A Socio-Rhetorical Commentary*](#). Eerdmans. 198.

Compare this to Paul's exhortation to rather be wronged or defrauded than initiate a lawsuit (1 Cor. 6:7).

Forced To Go a Mile / Go Two Miles

"Forced to go" (Greek: *angareusein*), is only used elsewhere to describe when Roman soldiers force a stranger to carry something.

Matthew 27:32 Instructor's Translation

As they were coming out, they found a man of Cyrene named Simon, whom **they forced into service** to bear his cross.

Forced to carry baggage by a Roman soldier. Jesus' example is specific to the 1st century Roman occupation of Palestine. A Roman soldier had the legal right to enlist any member of the subject population for forced labor.

One mile was apparently the legal limit, but Jesus calls on the disciples to offer another. To do this for anyone is remarkable; to do it for an enemy is more than remarkable.

"The verb *aggareuō* is technical. It is a Persian loanword, having reference originally to compulsory service in the postal system. It is found in a number of imperial documents in connection with the commandeering of pack animals and grain boats for the conveyance of military supplies, and it occurs as a loanword in the rabbinic literature with the same meaning. There is ample evidence that soldiers were frequently guilty of abusing their right to impress local civilians and that this was a cause of great resentment. Apart from Matt. 5:41 the only allusion to the practice in the New Testament is found in Mark 15:21 and parallels, where Simon of Cyrene is impressed into carrying Jesus' cross. ... It is significant, however, that the unit of distance here specified is the Roman milion (from which our English "mile" is derived), not the Greek stadion that is used for longer distances everywhere else in the New Testament (e.g., Luke 24:13; John 6:19). Even Josephus, in his many discussions of Rome's war with the Jews, consistently uses stadion, never

million, despite the fact that he writes in Rome under the patronage of the emperor! Jesus' use of "mile" would have sounded as foreign to his audience as "kilometer" in an American conversation. His hearers undoubtedly perceived therein an allusion to the occupying power."

Hare, Douglas R. A. (1993). [Matthew](#). Westminster John Knox Press. 56-57.

"Jesus advocated a response to the Roman occupation which not only full-blown Zealots but even the ordinarily patriotic populace would have found incomprehensible."

France, R. T. (2007). [The Gospel of Matthew, The New International Commentary on the New Testament](#). Eerdmans. 222.

To carry the load is an act of scandalous generosity; it subverts the power dynamics of the relationship and creates a human connection.

Carrying the load two miles is both a demonstration of generosity and a testament to your control over your body, not the oppressor. You have the dignity to choose what you will do, and you will use that power to serve.

This response disrupts the power inequity and the value gap that exist between the soldier and the occupied.

Give to the One Who Asks

Be generous way beyond your normal habits and comfort zone. Crazy stuff happens.

"A virtue-ethics approach makes best sense of what Jesus is saying here. ... He is not offering a new legal principle that overturns the Mosaic law. Rather, Jesus offers ethical wisdom. ... A decontextualized, literalist reading of Jesus' illustrations don't require us to cultivate the wisdom needed in real life situations where we encounter violent evil, situations that require resistance ... These illustrations are just that; they are not to be applied without wise exceptions. The command to turn the other cheek does not envision the situation of a child and an abusive parent, for example. ... Jesus offers a vision of virtue, how to be in the world that aligns with God's will, but working it out in individual lives, this requires wisdom."

Pennington, Jonathan (2017). [The Sermon on the Mount and Human Flourishing](#). Baker Academic. 197-198.

"Nonviolence is a powerful and just weapon, which cuts without wounding and ennobles the man who wields it. It is a sword that heals. The ultimate weakness of violent retaliation is that it is a descending spiral, begetting the very thing it seeks to destroy. Instead of diminishing evil, it multiplies it. Through violence you may murder the liar, but you cannot murder the lie, nor establish the truth. Through violence you may murder the hater, but you do not murder hate. In fact, violence merely increases hate. So it goes. Returning evil for evil multiplies evil, adding deeper darkness to a night already devoid of stars. Darkness cannot drive out darkness: only light can do that. Hate cannot drive out hate: only love can do that. Love is the only force capable of transforming an enemy into a friend."

King Jr., Martin Luther (2010). [Strength to Love](#). Beacon Press.

"Nonviolence is the answer to the crucial political and moral questions of our time: the need for man to overcome oppression and violence without resorting to oppression and violence. Man must evolve for all

human conflict a method which rejects revenge, aggression and retaliation. The foundation of such a method is love.”

King Jr., Martin Luther (1964). Nobel Peace Prize Acceptance Speech. Oslo, Norway.

Reflection Question

How do you understand the meaning of Jesus’ words, “do not resist-in-kind an evil person” in Matthew 5:39?

How do the examples he gives afterwards help clarify his teaching?